



Seeing your tiny baby hooked up to monitors and tubes can be alarming, but take comfort from the fact that these are helping your baby to breathe and feed and in turn to develop.

PREDICTING PREMATURE LABOR

It's hard to predict who will go into labor prematurely. However, if you've had a previous preterm birth, tests may be done to find out if it is likely in your current pregnancy. A cervical scan may be done around 23 weeks since a shorter cervix increases the risk of early labor. Pelvic swabs detect bacteria that are linked to preterm labor, and a "fetal fibronectin" shows whether a protein is present that, during the second half of pregnancy, generally can't be detected until 1–3 weeks before labor and delivery. Sometimes, a short cervix is strengthened with a stitch. Antibiotics can be given if needed. Progesterone can be given to reduce the risk of the baby being born prematurely.